

Algorithms 2

Clustering Algorithms

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1. The k -Centre Problem

- $[n]$ — n **data points**
- $D := (d_{ij})$ — symmetric distance matrix:
 - $d_{ii} = 0$ for all i
 - $d_{ij} \geq 0$ for all $i, j \in [n]$
- D satisfies the **$\triangle$ -inequality**:

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For $S \subseteq [n]$ and $i \in [n]$, define the **distance from i to S** :

$$d(i, S) := \min_{j \in S} d_{ij}$$

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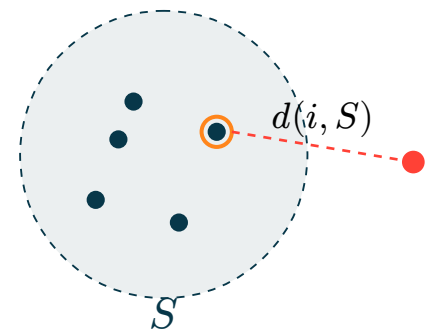
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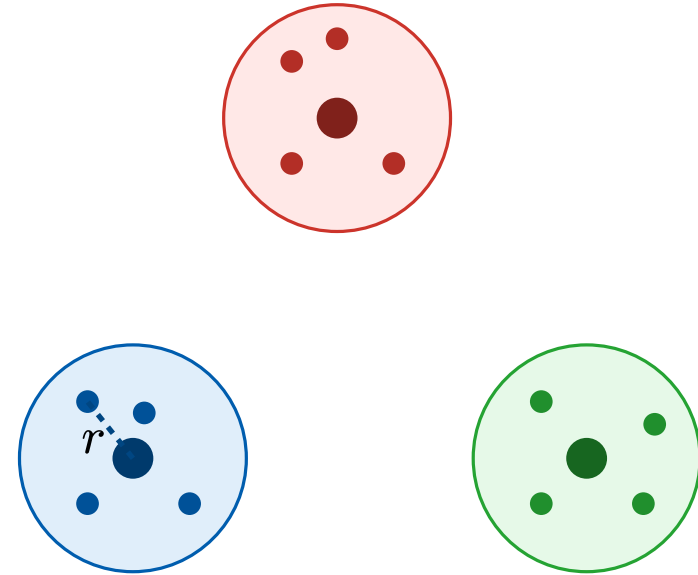
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Service points = filled dots

Algorithm 1: Greedy k -Centre

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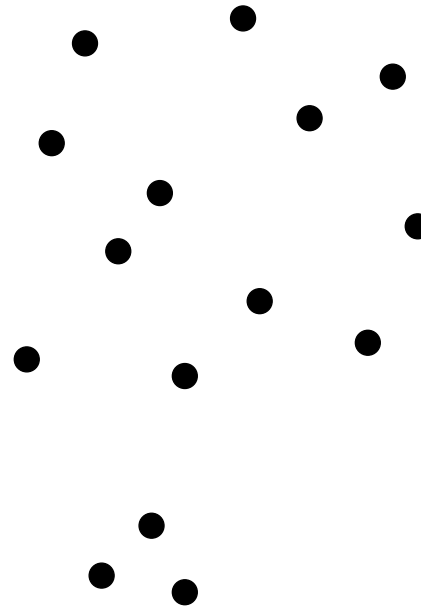
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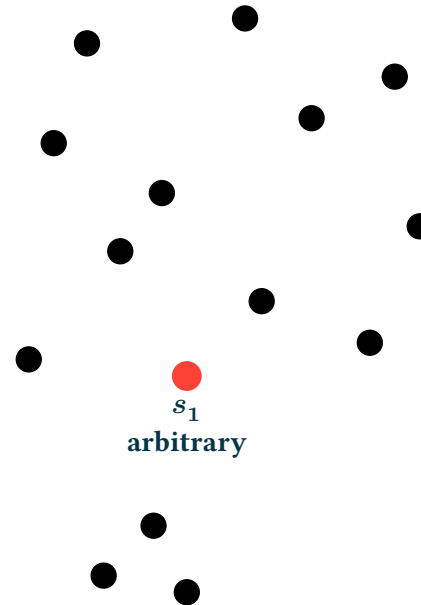
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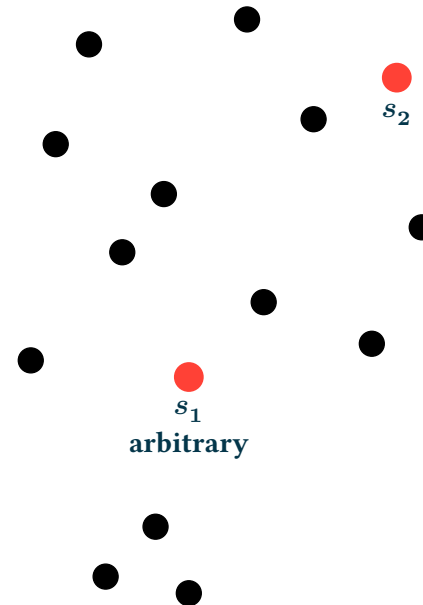
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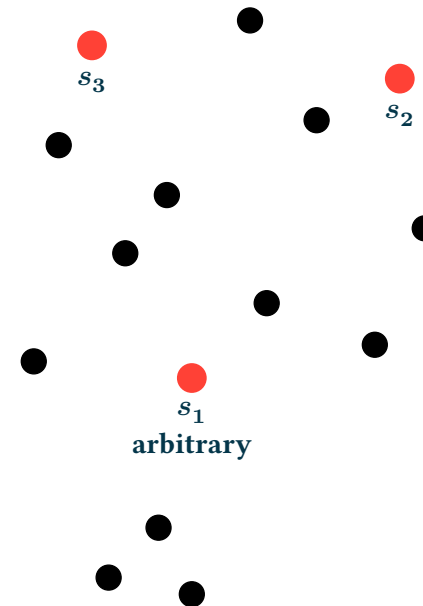
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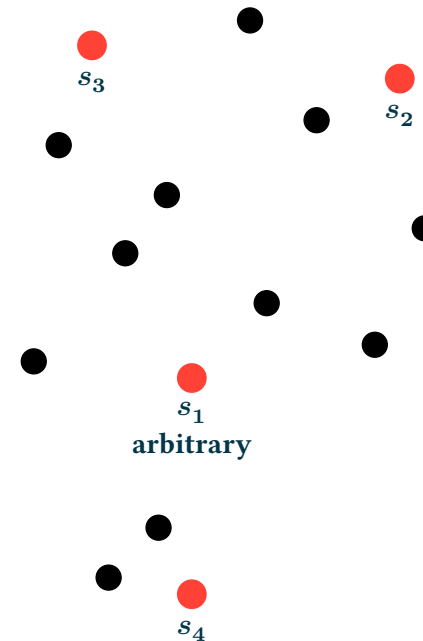
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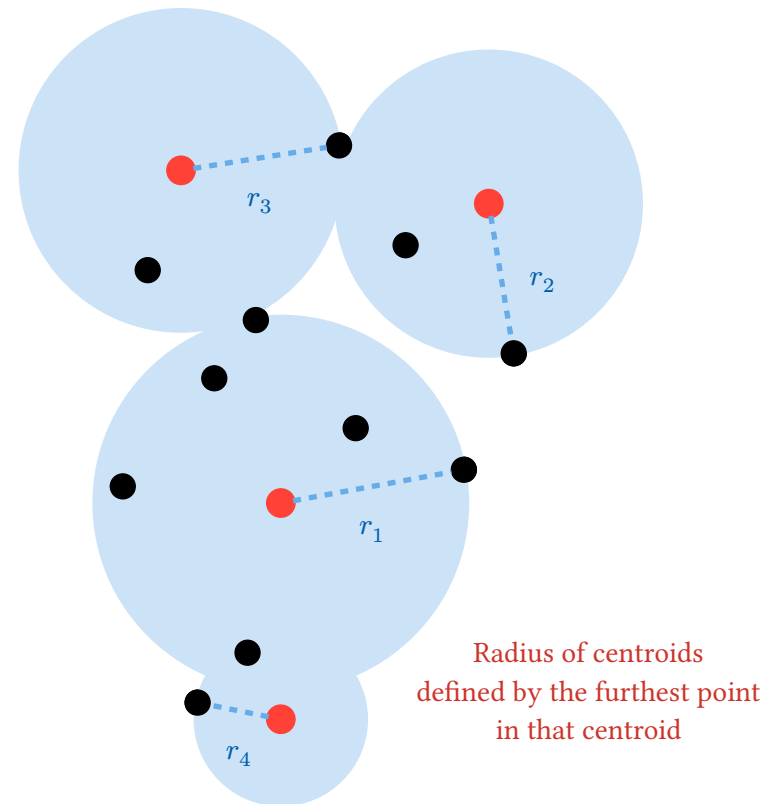
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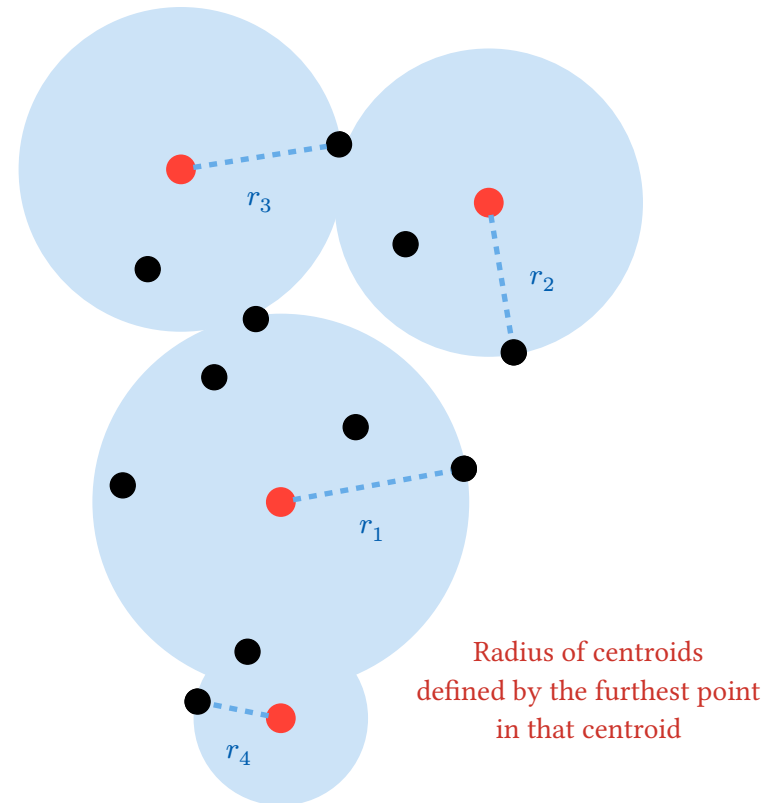
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How Good is the greedy algorithm?

2. Approximation Algorithms

Definition 2.1.1 An algorithm A for a **minimisation** problem Π is an **f -approximation** for Π if

$$A(I) \leq f \cdot \text{OPT}(I)$$

for every instance I of Π . Here $A(I)$ is A 's output and $\text{OPT}(I)$ the optimal value.

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Remark

We don't define $A(I) \leq \text{OPT}(I) + f$ because “hardly any problems will satisfy this.”

Back to k -centre. It is a **minimisation** problem, so:

- I = an instance of k -centre
- $\text{OPT}(I) := \min_{S \subseteq [n], |S|=k} \max_{i \in [n]} d(i, S)$

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That is: if S is the greedy output ($|S| = k$), then

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Two messages:

1. The greedy gives a solution at most **twice** the optimal radius.
2. **No polynomial-time algorithm can do better** (unless $P = NP$) — we will not prove this.

3. Proof of 2-Approximation

Let $S^* = \{j_1, j_2, \dots, j_k\} \subseteq [n]$ be an **optimal solution** and

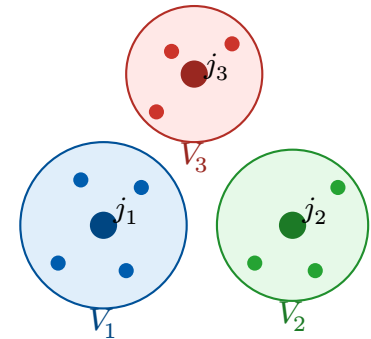
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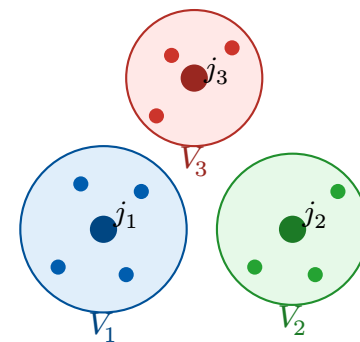


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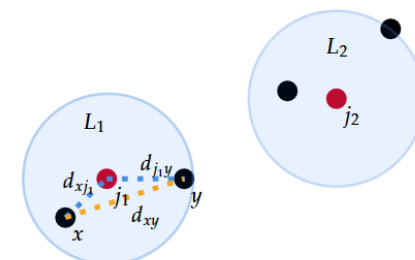
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Observation 3.1.1 Let $i \in [k]$ and $x, y \in V_i$. Then $d_{xy} \leq 2r^*$.

Proof: $d_{xy} \leq d_{xj_i} + d_{j_iy} \leq r^* + r^* = 2r^*$. $\square$



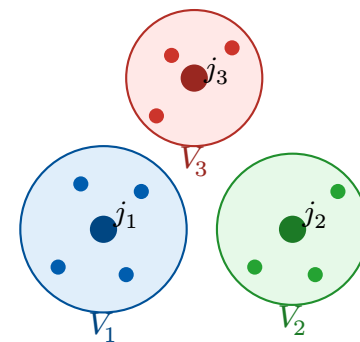
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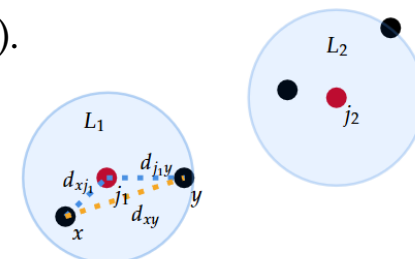


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Let $S_+ = \{s_1, \dots, s_k\}$ be the **greedy output**. Set $r := \max_{i \in [n]} d(i, S_+)$ (radius of S_+).

Current goal: $r \leq 2r^*$.



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We consider two cases based on how the greedy centres S_+ interact with the optimal partition:

Case 1: $|S_+ \cap V_i| = 1$ for all $i \in [k]$.

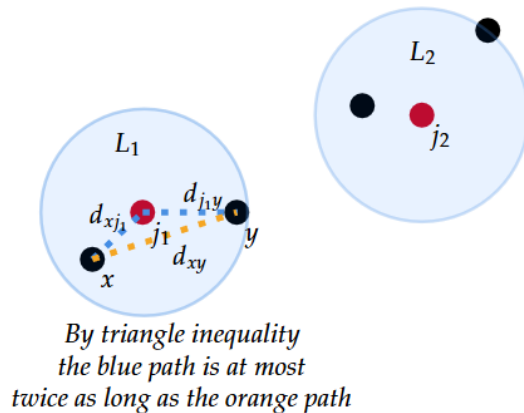
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Done! $r \leq 2r^*$. $\square$



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Case 2: $\exists i \in [k]$ s.t. $|S_+ \cap V_i| \geq 2$.

Some V_i contains **two** greedy centres; call them s, s' (WLOG s was chosen first).

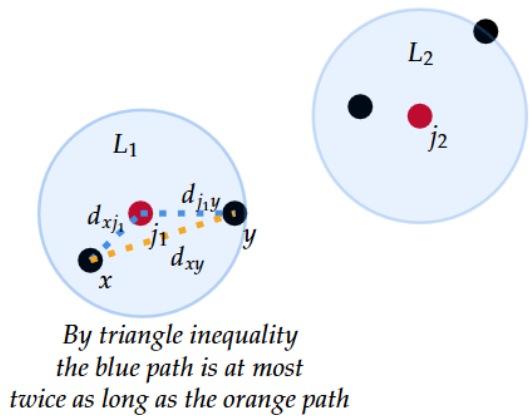
By the observation: $d_{ss'} \leq 2r^*$ (since $s, s' \in V_i$).

When s' was chosen, s was **already in** S_+ . The greedy picks the **farthest** point from the current S_+ , so at that moment every other point p satisfies:

$$d(p, S_+) \leq d(s', S_+^*) \leq d_{ss'} \leq 2r^*,$$

where S_+^* is S_+ at the moment before s' was added to it.

Hence $r = \max_{i \in [n]} d(i, S_+) \leq 2r^*$. $\square$



4. The k -Suppliers Problem

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Given: $[n] = A \cup B$, $k \in \mathbb{N}$, $|A| \geq k$.

- A = **suppliers** (facilities)
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Find: $S \subseteq A$, $|S| = k$, minimising

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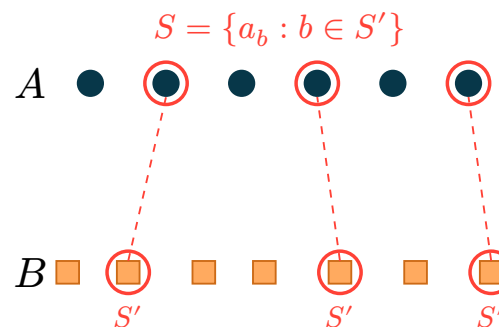
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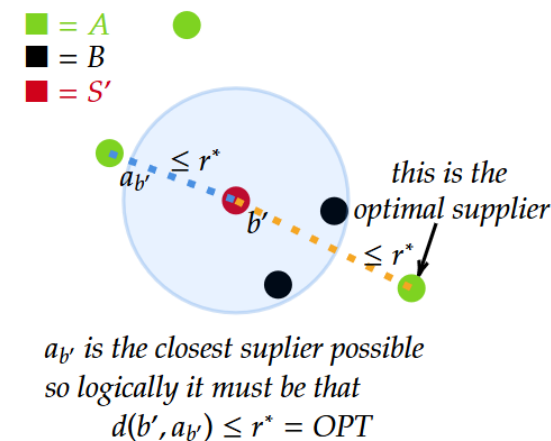
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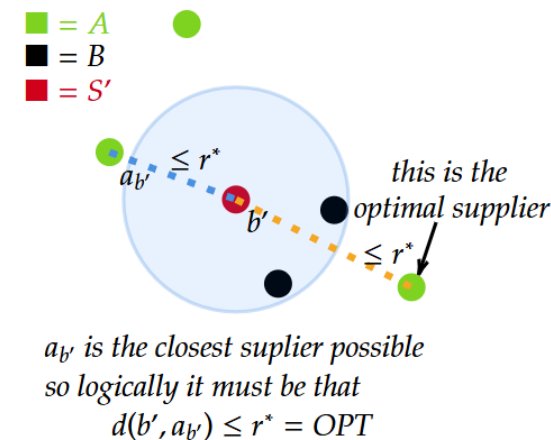
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By the triangle inequality and the claim:

$$d(b, a_{b'}) \leq \underbrace{d(b, b')}_{\leq 2r^*} + \underbrace{d(b', a_{b'})}_{\leq r^*} \leq 3r^*. \quad \square$$



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(proved on next slide)

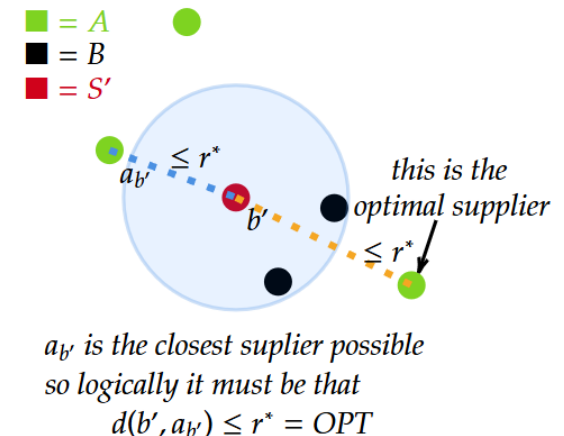
Since $a_{b'}$ is the nearest supplier to b' and OPT covers every client within r^* : $d(b', a_{b'}) \leq r^*$.

By the triangle inequality and the claim:

$$d(b, a_{b'}) \leq \underbrace{d(b, b')}_{\leq 2r^*} + \underbrace{d(b', a_{b'})}_{\leq r^*} \leq 3r^*. \quad \square$$

Remark

One can show that no polynomial-time f -approximation with $f < 3$ exists for k -suppliers (unless $P = NP$).



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Proof (by contradiction). Suppose $d(b, S') > 2r^*$ for some $b \in B$.

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- When each $b'_j \in S'$ was selected, greedy chose the **farthest** point, so: $d(b'_j, S'_{j-1}) \geq d(b, S'_{j-1}) \geq d(b, S') > 2r^*$.
- Hence **every pair** in $S' \cup \{b\}$ is $> 2r^*$ apart — a set of $k + 1$ points.

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The optimal solution uses only k suppliers. By **pigeonhole**, two points $u, v \in S' \cup \{b\}$ share the same nearest supplier $a \in A$:

$$d(u, v) \leq d(u, a) + d(a, v) \leq r^* + r^* = 2r^*.$$

But $d(u, v) > 2r^*$ — **contradiction.** $\square$